

Research Paper: The Historical Jesus

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So was Jesus real? We need to answer this question on a personal level, but also on a scholarly level. Our faith is constantly tested with this question when we want to sin in the face of the omniscient and omnipresent God. But on the scholarly level, we are tasked with answering the atheist and science with whether believing in Jesus is reasonable or not. To understand the true Jesus - the real Jesus - is the quest for the Historical Jesus. In this paper, I will examine whether it is reasonable to believe that the gospels are historical, that Jesus is real, and whether the historical Jesus reinforces our faith or not.

According to Reimarus, Jesus was a fraud. Walczak's paper says that Reimarus was the "pioneer of the historical Jesus." And yet, Reimarus is written to say that the divinity of Jesus was a "deception by the apostles." That Jesus was a "pretender." And that Jesus was "seeking to overthrow the Roman occupation." Now, as educated Christians, we know that all these claims are false. But if a non-believer or even Reimarus himself were to say these claims to you, how would you respond? Would you respond with anger and blindly reinforce the faith of the Christians? Or would you have an educated response that can reason with the smartest of atheists? I want to address some of the claims of Reimarus and show in this paper how I would address his atheistic claims.

According to our lectures, the Calvin Seminary professor says that the Jews memorized every detail of Jesus' ministry in order to write it down later. This testimony, which is the gospels, is the best source of history for Jesus. Thus, if Reimarus is the "pioneer of historical Jesus" as claimed in Walczak's paper, Reimarus must look almost solely at the gospels. And of course, the gospels show that Jesus is divine and God.

When Reimarus says that Jesus' divinity is a deception by the apostles, we must face the question, "Who are we to believe?" The question of Jesus' divinity is questioned by Jesus when Jesus asks the disciples, "Who do you say I am?" We will never be able to prove that Jesus is divine, we will only be able to confess what we believe and what we think is true. This is because as the Bible says, "we live by faith, not by sight," and that we "hope for a better future" that has not been received yet (Romans).

Now, Raimarus says that Jesus was a pretender¹. This is the same claims that people made in the gospels, like the pharisees. Thus, we encounter nothing new, and we can defend the Biblical Jesus by saying, "We must just believe what the gospels and the letters claim of Jesus and that claiming Jesus is a pretender is like claiming he casts out demons by the prince of demons."

Reimarus says that Jesus was "seeking to overthrow the Roman occupation." This is easily countered with the fact that Jesus said to give to Caesar what belongs to Caesar. And did Jesus overthrow the Romans? No, he died a crucified death - he was not a threat to the Romans.

The second paper² I will examine is that of Rowlands. Rowlands says that the research of the historical Jesus is done in a framework, and trying to be objective by creating a "secular metaphysical framework," or "secularism," is not a good idea. This is because "secular reasoning is not a metaphysically neutral system of thought."

According to Rowlands, we can never achieve some objective stance that shows the "Historical Jesus." The gospels are tainted with the beliefs and stances of the writers of

¹ Walczak, Marcin. 2024. "Divinity of Christ in the Light of the Quest for the Historical Jesus." *Verbum Vitae* 42 (2): 471–91. doi:10.31743/vv.16812.

² Rowlands, Jonathan. 2021. "The Metaphysics of Historical Jesus Research: An Argument for Increasing the Plurality of Metaphysical Frameworks within Historical Jesus Research." *Tyndale Bulletin* 72: 101–4. doi:10.53751/001c.31748.

the gospels, and are pointed toward a religion of Christianity. If we try to create some secularism, we will eventually create atheism - something that simply says, "I don't believe in God," as opposed to "I believe in God." It's that simple, the historical Jesus is who you want Jesus to be - in the end, everything is faith, and we need to place our faith that the historical Jesus was God, and others may have the faith to believe otherwise. But in the end, we will never construct some historical Jesus where we can clearly see the answer. As the gospels say, it is better to believe without seeing or touching, than to be like Thomas and believe after touching Jesus' wounds.

Stevensons' article³ on understanding a Metaphysical Reading of the Historical Jesus teaches us that history cannot be objective. I think this is the greatest theme and fact that must be taken away from a quest for the historical Jesus - we will never be able to be objective - history is always slanted by a certain viewpoint. In my class for sermons, I learned that everyone views a car crash differently - there will be 10 different accounts of what happened if 10 people witnessed it. Thus, Stevenson in his paper says that "motivation and intention" is crucial in understanding the portrait of Jesus painted "in order to illuminate the self-understanding of a historical individual." What Stevenson is saying is, a person delves into the quest for the historical Jesus with certain intentions and motives, which taint what his conclusions are. And every portrait of the historical Jesus is tainted with a viewpoint. In the end, Stevenson says that "all history is the history of thought" - "History is not processes of mere events but processes of actions, the inner side consisting of processes of thought." This means

³ Stevenson, Austin. 2019. "The Self-Understanding of Jesus: A Metaphysical Reading of Historical Jesus Studies." *Scottish Journal of Theology* 72 (3): 291–307. doi:10.1017/s0036930619000346.

that history is not recording actions, but our perception of actions and our thoughts of events, which means that our beliefs taint the picture.

I want to create a scenario that shows this point in illustration. Let's say Jesus changes the water to wine. The disciples will write this in the gospels as a miracle. But doubters and non-believers will write this as some sort of trick, or some sort of deception - that it never happened, or that it was evil or the prince of demons. Do you see? This is exactly what happened in the gospels and is happening today. We have the perfect gospels and people are viewing it one way or another. Even when we have objective viewing 2000 years ago of the actual events, there would have been the same problem. So my takeaway is this: we are never going to be able to go 2000 years back and witness the actual events, and even if we did, our beliefs will taint our perception of it. So, get to the point and ask yourself, "What do I believe? Who is Jesus? What do I believe?" We must believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the Living God as Peter confessed.

According to my final source⁴, which is written by Meggitt, we learn that it is so obvious that Jesus at least existed. No scholar of the New Testament doubts the existence of Jesus. What we can learn from this fact is that if Jesus existed, and if the documents of his birth are true, he fulfills countless prophecies and that he must be the Messiah and he must be God. Meggitt says that it is "so weak or bizarre" to doubt that Jesus existed in the scholarly New Testament community. However, it is "culturally prominent in recent years." "40 percent of respondents do not believe that Jesus 'actually lived.'" This statistic shows that the growing population is doubting Jesus in

⁴ Meggitt, Justin J (Justin James). 2019. "More Ingenious than Learned?": Examining the Quest for the Non-Historical Jesus." *New Testament Studies* 65 (4): 443–60. doi:10.1017/s0028688519000213.

spite of all rationality. Once again, rationality is associated with the smartest of Christian scholars and with God himself, and so it is clear and obvious and understandable to see that atheists are not being rational and are going against the facts. All the facts point to Jesus being God.

Another thing we can learn is that when people are searching for the historical Jesus, they are looking for an alternate explanation to Jesus, other than the religious Christian one⁵. We must have pity and sympathize with those who do not believe, and pray for them, and we must argue and look at the facts and present facts to them in hope that they see that the historical Jesus is pointed to the true God. If they run away from this, they are only running into the infinite depths of irrationality, where there is no hope if they want to reject the Creator.

And to clarify my motive, I want to understand the historical Jesus because I want to be objective. I want to be truly objective as much as I can, but I understand that this objectivity is bound in Christianity and rationality. I want to understand the world from a general revelation and scientific point of view that adds and supplements and reinforces my faith. I believe that the world and general revelation is good. God created the world and he created it with wisdom and called it good. We must also use all our mind and strength to understand God and to worship him in science as well as history. By understanding history as well as the atheists, we can bring true academics to colleges and make colleges teach things that glorify God.

The search for the historical Jesus is a necessary thing. We don't want the historical Jesus to conflict with the gospels. We want the Jesus that is confirmed by

⁵ Van Oudtshoorn, Andre. 2021. "The Insignificant Impact of the Historical Jesus." In *Die Skriflig* 55 (1): 1–10. doi:10.4102/ids.v55i1.2756.

academic historians, to align with the truth we find in the religion of Christianity. We find that people are going to be apologetics and deny the faith. We need to be apologetics that affirm the faith. The truth of the gospels should be confirmed by reality. This means that it should be confirmed by archaeology. It should also be confirmed by philosophy. And in this case, it should be confirmed by history. The reason why so many people do not believe in Christianity is because it does not align with the facts. However, if we show that it does align with the facts then it'll allow them to believe.

Thus, the search for the historical Jesus is just one search for affirming the apologetics of Christianity. History is one objective study or field of study that should confirm the truth of Christianity. Some of the related topics is the canonicity of the Old Testament and the New Testament. However, the most important question in all of life is: is Jesus real? Thus, the historicity of the New Testament, and of the Old Testament is not as important as the historicity of Jesus Christ.

One big topic in the Faith is blind Faith. Should Faith be blind or should Faith be informed and confirmed with evidence from history? This is an important question and I believe that both are correct. We need to have blind faith, but we also need to have informed faith. One of the truths about faith is that it is blind. The Bible says that we are not living by sight, we are living by Faith. This means that Faith is blind.

However, are we gonna leave it at this? Of course not because Faith is supposed to be informed and not completely blind. We are given some knowledge and some facts and some sight in order to make decisions about God and be realistic about God. The reason why we have special revelation and the Bible is to have some sight in addition to our Faith. The Bible is not a blind guide. We need Faith in order to

understand it. However, with faith, we gain sight and understanding of the world. This is the truth about the historicity of Jesus Christ. It is not supposed to replace Faith, it is supposed to add sight to the Faith. It is not supposed to give sight instead of Faith.

Because God created the world, he created history to be good. Thus, we are not to deny all of the history and all the studies of the colleges. The atheists have a glimmer of truth. We must reason together. Satan is not completely just saying random things. He often says things that are correct. Thus, we must play Satan's game. We must beat him. The historical Jesus is the Jesus that was in history. This is a factual truth. Thus, all archaeology in all history should add up together to point to the truth. And if Jesus is the way in the truth and the life, archaeology should confirm this. The true historical Jesus is the Jesus of the Bible that we believe in.

One of the most important facts of the historical of Jesus is that it is tinged with belief. When a car crash is witnessed by 10 people 10 different testimonies appear. Thus, the fact that the gospels are testimony is testimony to the fact that it is honest. It does not seem to be some objective source. It claims to come from eyewitnesses. And if you know anything about your own memory, you will know that you never witness or remember anything perfectly. Thus, we come to the philosophical question: what is truth? And once again, I want to say to the reader: we need to believe in Jesus Christ. Without Faith, we have no sight. We cannot have sight without Faith. The reason why Faith is so important that it gives us access to the truth. The Bible says the people who did not believe were blinded and deaf. If you do not have faith, you have no sight.

One of the questions that always comes up is: is there an objective truth? And I think we can all say yes because we can also say that 1+1 equals two. No culture

would say otherwise. However, the question is: what is the truth? How do we know what the truth is? We may know that there is an objective truth, but what is the quality and the details of it? The only way to know is to live the life and to read the books, especially the gospels. We have to make up our own mind. So what do you think? Is Jesus real?

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